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Never Again is Right Now

The Rise of the AfD in Germany

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LETTER FROM THE EDITORS

Dear Readers,

Welcome to the last issue of the 2023-2024 school year and the first issue of the 2024-2025 Managing Board! We, Samantha Moon and Theo Sotoodehnia, your new Editors-in–Chief, are beyond excited to share this issue with you. In compiling this issue, we have had the pleasure of working alongside an incredible new team. Phoenix Boggs and Grey Battle, both Political Science majors, are our stellar Online Managing Editors. Alexia Dochnal, a Political Science and Philosophy double major, and Sovy Pham, an American Studies major, serve as our new Print Managing Editors. History major Eliza Daunt is pioneering the role of Multimedia Managing Editor and manages our photojournalism as well as media initiatives like documentaries and podcasts. Our Managing Board is rounded out by our phenomenal Publisher, Owen Haywood, an Economics and Global Affairs double major.

This issue kicks off with "The Shelf Life of Relevance" by Victoria Vilton, which examines the longevity of fame. It continues with "Journalism isn't Dying, it's transforming," in which Lily Belle Poling explores technology's effects on local journalism. In our cover story, "Never Again is Right Now," Nicole Chen chronicles the rise of the AFD in Germany and examines the growing backlash the far-right party faces from segments of German society. Alessandra Pappalardi then discusses challenges facing the fishing industry in New England in her article, "The Bounty of the Sea." The penultimate article is an interview with author Zaina Arafat by Sophia Liu, "Interrogating Identity," in which Arafat discusses identity and her book *You Exist Too Much*. The issue concludes with "Street Politics," a photo essay by Rory Schoenberger, which explores political graffiti and street art in New Haven.

Our journey as a Managing Board is just beginning, and we are so excited to see where the coming year takes us. We hope you enjoy this issue as much as we enjoyed putting it together!

With Love,
Samantha Moon and Theo Sotoodehnia
Editors-in-Chief

Cover Photo Credit: Thomas Imo/photothek/picture alliance

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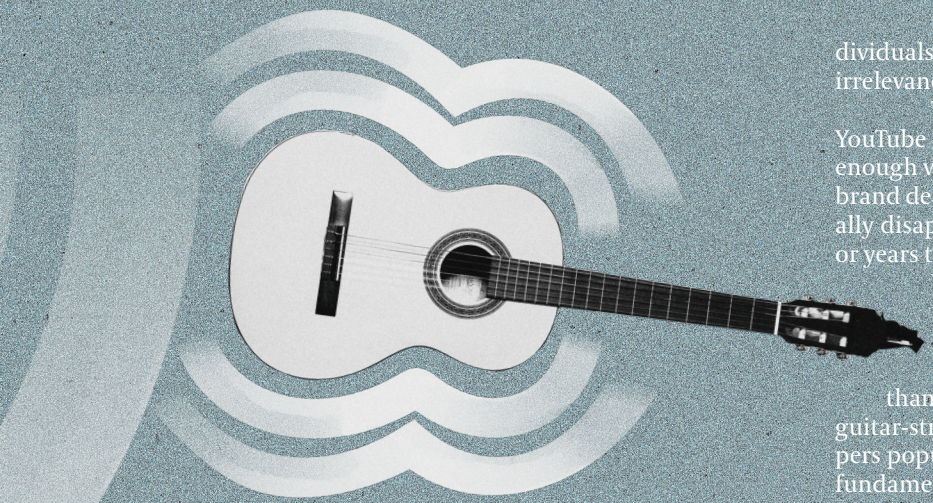
THE SHELF LIFE O

WHAT DICTATES THE LONGEVITY OF FAME?

BY: **VICTORIA VILTON**

F RELEVANCE



When The Beatles flew from Liverpool, England to New York City in 1964, they had no idea they would become some of the most important men in music history. Sporting shiny black boots, perfectly starched suits, and identical mop-top hairstyles, their appearance on the Ed Sullivan Show, broadcast to over 73 million people across the country, ignited "Beatlemania" and found fans among high-school girls and music critics alike.

Over a half-century and the passing of two band members later, fans still tuned in en masse for the November 2023 release of "Now and Then," the last Beatles song recorded featuring all four members. The song was created from a salvaged John Lennon demo tape and refined by McCartney, Harrison, and Starr in the '90s, before its completion in 2023.

"Now and Then" performed impressively, reaching number one on the U.K. charts and becoming the country's fastest-selling vinyl record of the 21st century.

It's been over 50 years since the Beatles broke up. Anyone who was a teenager when Beatlemania arrived in the United States is now well past retirement age. Yet, a considerable crowd still anticipated the release of music by a group that should be, by virtue of time, irrelevant. Why does Paul McCartney still sell out stadiums? Why do people still care?

Time creates natural endpoints that every public figure must at some point reckon with. No group lives forever, as no individual lives forever. The Beatles were together for a meager seven years, yet their influence is felt across contemporary music. They are not just popular amongst the generations that grew up with them, but with younger listeners as well: 30% of the Beatles' Spotify streams come from people aged 18 to 24. Conversely, groups like The Yardbirds or The Band, who were renowned in their time, have faded from present cultural consciousness.

Few recent celebrities seem able to capture the public's attention quite as comprehensively as the Beatles have. Celebrity culture today is dominated by bite-sized celebrities who, after a short stint of fame, fade into insignificance. While one-hit wonders have always ridden the wave of a successful single to short-term fame, previously, musicians were constantly creating, performing, and promoting to prove themselves to be signed by exclusive industry executives. Technology—especially the rise of social media—has accelerated the rate at which individuals can acquire fame, briefly enjoy it, and then fade into irrelevance.

Take the dozens of micro-influencers on TikTok or YouTube who follow a now familiar career trajectory: posting enough videos online to be considered a public figure, securing brand deals, and releasing the occasional single, only to eventually disappear. Levels of fame that previously required months or years to achieve can now materialize in hours or days.

Which begs the question: Is there a shelf life to relevance? What enables some artists to remain relevant for decades, while others fade?

Today, carbon copies are far easier to find than musical revolutionaries. Hundreds of soft-spoken, guitar-strumming musicians and colorful-haired, tattooed rappers populate our culture and streaming sites. The internet has fundamentally altered the way people consume music. Instead of waiting in line for a cassette or a vinyl record, one can search for music in seconds and skip through songs without giving them a chance. The internet "supercharges the rate of information," said Daniel Harrison, a professor of Musical Theory in the Department of Music at Yale University. An increased access to celebrities and their work is a byproduct.

It is easier to become famous today than it was half a century ago. One must only upload a short video to the internet and wait for views to roll in. This ease can platform controversial figures with incendiary audiences or, in the case of a musician like Noah Kahan—who had been making music that flew under the radar for years before finally gaining popularity on TikTok—can kickstart a career that may have been otherwise impossible.

Many criticize the ease and speed of modern fame. Creating and sharing music on social media with rapid production leads many music critics to characterize social media-based artists as disingenuous and cheap. Lindsay Wright, an Associate Professor in the Yale Department of Music argues that the dominance of the Internet in celebrity culture is not necessarily negative. "Every time technology evolves, things often speed up in certain ways. Communication chains get more extended, and people from further and different places can access things. TikTok is the most recent little tiny step and a very, very long history of all of us being more interconnected in ways that are liberating," she said.

Still, some disillusioned consumers feel the modern high-speed reality detracts from the quality of work. "The older music was created by humans with passion and soul for their craft. That's why their music is timeless—it is a gift for multiple generations to love," said Iris Levine, a music photographer from Bell Bottom Blues Productions in Long Island, New York. "New celebrities are in [it] for the followers they gain and dollars they bring in. There is a certain coldness to it."

So, what is the difference between the modern-age products and The Beatles? What made The Beatles the subject of countless musical biographies and documentaries? Is there something beyond the advent of social media, something more fundamental, that sets them apart?

Daniel Harrison said that the answer to these questions lies in the 16th and 17th centuries, when "composers were remembered and their works were performed even after they died." Musical notation catalyzed the enduring memory of composition, and later, composers. Medieval religious figures

desired their congregations to sing and pray in unison, so they developed a means of expressing music on paper. Their sheet music was certainly less intuitive than the form used today, but it allowed for the growth of music beyond the bounds of human mortality and memory. As musical notation developed, composers could increase the longevity of their work and thereby allow their renown to persist long past their individual deaths.

Accelerating past the 16th and 17th centuries and the historical context that spurred the birth of the musical celebrity, other societal factors have influenced fame and audience reception of a particular musical act—namely, youth culture. "It started in the 20s, with the recognition of [a misbehaving] youth generation. First by drinking when it was made illegal. Then by hairstyles, short skirts, [lewd] dance styles, racial mixing. In the 50s, it came back, and rock'n'roll [had] all the same themes," said Harrison. The early 20th century saw a rapid development in almost all aspects of daily life—technology became steadily more widespread and accessible, and younger generations rebelled against a restrictive status quo. Youth culture started to shape popular culture, facilitating the growth of the celebrity figure, fandom culture, and public investment in the lives of celebrities. Musicians served the general public something they needed and wanted— something revolutionary.

It was the revolutionary nature of The Beatles that made them so successful. "They never stopped creating and never stopped pushing musical boundaries. They simultanously fit into the current cultural zeitgeist but also propelled it forward and created a new set of norms and standards for the rock n roll scene," said Carl Gedeon, a lawyer in New York City and an enthusiastic music fan.

The Beatles began their careers by catering to a well-liked musical genre before venturing further and developing styles of their own. The longevity of an artist's fame depends, in part, on their ability to cater to a cultural moment.

Those who are unquestionably successful are, Gedeon argues, "artists whose timing on the music scene either fit the current cultural zeitgeist or artists who were so revolutionary that they actually changed the current cultural zeitgeist."

Over time, the Beatles' image evolved. The mop-tops and suits disappeared, with mustaches and psychedelic-inspired outfits materializing in their wake. Their music became less pop and more dynamic and experimental. Over their seven years as a group, John Lennon, Paul McCartney, George Harrison, and Ringo Starr transformed the musical world. The Beatles began squarely in the mainstream but pushed the public into uncharted territory. This phenomenon is not unique to The Beatles, and it did not end with them.

Taylor Swift is a prime example of the type of fluid celebrity society craves. She began her career as a small-town country singer, settling within a comfortable niche of a teenage, female, predominately white, audience, singing about love and heartbreak. Swift was young and exciting and brought an innocent freshness to the music industry. When her fanbase demanded an outspoken female figure to represent their changing values, Swift's presentation evolved. She now symbolizes female empowerment for generations of women, having reclaimed ownership of her music from her original record label. Swift strategically taps into musical trends and plans her collaborations for maximum virality. Is it the case, then, that any musician may maintain fame if they tailor their art to fit contemporary desires?

Beyoncé is another artist who gained fame by first fitting the zeitgeist and then making it her own, fulfilling the needs of a mainstream white world while also maintaining ties to a Black audience. "[Beyoncé's] story of race and misogynoir and her understanding of how to translate it for the mainstream white world in a way that's still innovative enough to capture the honest admiration of the Black-American world is a balancing act not many people have managed," said Lindsay Wright. Beyoncé's early career saw her standing out in a girl group that represented early 2000s music and fashion culture. When she transitioned into a solo artist, her music changed with her, solidifying her status as the mononymous Beyoncé—a figure for the white-dominated mainstream and Black worlds alike. Such tension is difficult to navigate, yet it is her success in doing so that makes her one of the most enduring artists of the 21st century.

Through sheer talent, hard work, and an acute awareness of the way they are perceived, Taylor Swift and Beyoncé stand out in a compelling and novel way. Audiences come to identify themselves not only in their music but in their journeys, growing with the artists as they progress from following trends to creating them. Consequently, artists like Taylor Swift and Beyoncé are propelled to a fame that is not easily lost.

The continued relevance of a musician relies on the judgment of their contemporaries. "There's celebrity fame, which is just being known in general, and then there's something more than that, which is people attributing greatness to someone for their actual skill," said Wright. Not only can the masses dictate what is considered good, but "we [can] rely on something more like the Grammys, [where] experts who actually understand the genre have decided that this is good according to some level of criteria based in knowledge and education," Wright continued. Accolades from genre critics signal "true greatness" to the public, delineating art which deserves further academic recognition. Musical figures can transform from "iconic" during a cultural moment to "important" for

form from "iconic" during a cultural moment to "important" for generations to come.

None of these factors alone explain why the success of certain artists endure and others fade. Technology has certainly changed, but it is in a constant state of evolution. Mozart endures across time, as does Ella Fitzgerald and The Beatles. Each started their career in different technological environments, yet maintained a continued public interest.

It might be that groups like the Beatles are the exception, not the rule. Enduring relevance seems to require a complex cocktail of timing, skill, style, and an ability to both move with and transform the public. Given the volatile and almost unreliable nature of public opinion, expiration dates remain conditional. The pure joy Beatles fans had for the release of "Now and Then" speaks for itself.

"I was ecstatic," said John Meuser, a music fan from New York City, "[It] proves again that brilliant music never sounds outdated." As long as people care—as long as great music means something to somebody—fame has no shelf life.

Journalism isn't dying, it's transforming: the metamorphosis of journalism in a digital age

BY: **LILY BELLE POLING**

Anne Fadiman lives in Western Massachusetts, where each morning she reads the print edition of The New York Times, purchased from the gas station by her husband, and The Daily Hampshire Gazette, which waits for her at the end of the driveway.

"I could not live without either," Fadiman, the Yale Francis Writer in Residence, wrote in an email to The Politic. "The Times has better writing and fewer typos, but the Gazette, which has been published since 1786, is an essential part of life around here. It keeps local politicians accountable, reports on schools, town budgets, the police department, and the LGBTQ community, and publishes letters on a wide variety of local matters. Our part of the world would be incomplete without it," she said.

According to Northwestern's Local News Initiative, as of 2023, "more than half of all the country's 3,100 counties either do not have a local news outlet or have only a single surviving outlet." Just as Fadiman's community would be "incomplete" without The Daily Hampshire Gazette, residents of these "news deserts" lack a reliable source of information about their community. 204 counties — home to over three million people — do not have a single news outlet at all.

Data from the Local News Initiative shows that the United States lost a third of its newspapers between 2005 and 2023. As of November 16, 2023, 6,005 papers remained—the overwhelming majority of which are weekly or other nondaily editions.

By 2023, newspapers were closing at a rate of more than two papers per week. Since 2005, the industry has lost about 60 percent of its newspaper journalists—more than 43,000 people.

The decline can be largely attributed to shifts in the news industry. Before the 21st century, newspapers relied on print advertising, which raised more than enough money to support operations and often allowed newspapers to be quite prosperous. As the 21st century ushered in the digital age, the

"The Times has better writing and fewer typos, but the Gazette, which has been published since 1786, is an essential part of life around here."

newspaper industry lost gargantuan sums of advertising revenue to platforms such as Craigslist, Google, EBay, and Facebook. But independent from this inevitable transition, publication owners also made a series of tragic mistakes when deciding how their newspapers were going to exist in this new era.

According to Walter Shapiro, a Yale professor of political science and award-winning journalist, most newspapers did not believe the Internet was a serious competitor, so they were slow to adapt to the new medium. Furthermore, newspapers assumed that having an online presence—which often produced free content—would increase their print circulation, when, in fact, it did the opposite.

"As a result, there was an expectation that was built out that news should be free. And the problem is advertising on the web brings in about 1/10 as much money as print advertising," Shapiro said, "So the combination of all these factors led to venerable newspapers closing or suddenly publishing in print two days a week."

According to the Pew Research Center, newspapers generated $49.4 billion in advertising revenue in 2005, compared to $8.8 billion in 2020—an 82 percent decrease. Although advertisements are not the only way for newspapers to bring in revenue, the sharp decline in revenue has made it difficult for many newspapers to stay afloat.

Regardless of the revenue loss, the ways young audiences consume media has fundamentally changed: many modern audiences prefer to read less and consume more audible and visual mediums. Another factor exacerbating the loss of small papers is the intervention of private equity and hedge funds in the newspaper market.

Margot Susca, author of Hedged: How Private Investment Funds Helped Destroy American Newspapers and Under-

Digital Transformation and Journalism Evolution

"It took a generation to unravel the industry. It will take another to bring it back"

mine Democracy, explained that, in 2003, there was a turning point in the industry when two private equity firms invested in a controlling stake of Freedom Communications, which operated a chain of daily and weekly newspapers. Although private equity firms had previously existed in the industry, this marked the turning point when firms began to hold majority shares of newspaper chains. With their influence as stakeholders, these investors pressured newspapers to make decisions that would maximize profits, but not benefit the well-being of the greater journalism industry. Strategies included for example, increasing subscription fees and shrinking reporter workforces. The 2008 recession intensified this trend: newspapers became distressed debt properties, and different private equity investors bought control of the distressed debt. Afterwards, hedge funds became the owners of many newspaper chains.

Alden Global Capital, for instance, owns the MediaNews and Tribune papers—a network of more than 200 newspapers in the United States—and operates a business model that lays off significant portions of newsroom staff, sells the newspapers' real estate, and raises subscription fees to make a quick profit until the papers are unable to operate. Rather than creating long-term investments with sustainable cash flow, Alden looks to wring as much money out of a newspaper as it can and then quickly moves on to its next conquest.

"The [newspaper] chains that have been influenced by these funds have had more layoffs; at some chains, the layoffs were double those of family owned chains, which also went through the same great recession and the same swings of advertising losses," Susca said, "They sell off buildings, printing plants, they just totally liquidate a company."

Even major national outlets that have managed to create sustainable business models in today's digital newspaper market have faced significant losses. Last October, The Washington Post announced a staff reduction of 240 individuals. National outlets, although not facing problems with private equity or hedge funds, have had to reconcile with the digital upheaval to the news industry in the same way local outlets have.

The loss of local news production has had significant consequences for the functioning of democracy at its most fundamental level.

In News Hole: The Demise of Local Journalism and Political Engagement, the authors found a direct correlation between a decrease in the number of local news stories in daily newspapers and a decline in voter participation. Interestingly, this lack of civic participation often gives incumbents an advantage or leads to straight-ticket voting along partisan lines. In fact, the Nieman Journalism Foundation's Nieman Lab at Harvard has found that the loss of local news directly leads to political polarization.

Joanne Lipman, acclaimed journalist and Yale lecturer on Media and Democracy, agreed a lack of local news leads to greater political polarization: "People end up just being swayed by whatever they're seeing on cable news, as opposed to when you have strong local news."
Lipman explained that local news is valuable not only because it holds local officials accountable, but also because it unites communities around things like sports, the local play, or school board decisions. Local news bolsters community ties and prevents people from becoming engrossed with national news and politics.

Beyond rising polarization, Walter Shapiro explained that corruption flourishes in the absence of press monitoring, citing examples of decreased coverage of state governments.

"Extremists flourish in this environment because no one is calling them out," he said, "Also, communities of color or immigrant communities can be neglected by either the city or state in which they reside without the press to call attention to the plight of these communities." Such plights, either willfully or accidentally ignored, will continue unheeded to a worse degree without local news, Shapiro continued.

Given these conditions, it is no surprise that countless publications describe journalism as "dying," "cratering," or

"in turmoil." Although many publications have reckoned with the changes to the industry or been forced to close their doors, the analysis that journalism is "dying" is misguided. Newspapers have been forced to adapt to the largest change in media the industry has ever seen.

"There will be something that emerges, and it will not look anything like the system that we used to have," Susca said, "And I think that for marginalized communities, that is a positive."

This digital revolution, however, does not change the fundamental principle that when people want to know something, they turn to the news. This principle will keep the industry alive indefinitely.

"It took a generation to unravel the industry. It will take another to bring it back," Graciela Mochkofsky, the dean of the Craig Newmark Graduate School of Journalism at the City University of New York, said on a panel at the Nieman Foundation's 20th Georges Conference on College Journalism.

Susca said that journalism is not dying, but it would never return to its original form. Scholars like Susca have traveled the United States researching possible solutions to the problems digital advertising and hedge funds have brought to newspapers.

"There will be something that emerges, and it will not look anything like the system that we used to have," Susca said, "And I think that for marginalized communities, that is a positive." Susca explained that even in print newspapers' heyday, the coverage was far from perfect. Newspapers tended to care only about the audiences their advertisers wanted to reach—often white suburban ones.

Moving forward, Joanne Lipman emphasized the importance of creating a new business model for journalism that can support itself without relying on advertising, which traditionally sustained the industry. According to Lipman, many new publications are experimenting with different models, particularly with the non-profit model, "but no one has figured out a self-sustaining business model that doesn't require infusions of philanthropic dollars at this point."

Nevertheless, philanthropic initiatives have made significant contributions to journalism, especially at the local scale, in recent times.

Dale Anglin, the director of Press Forward—an initiative to invest in and expand access to local news explained the ways in which philanthropy can make meaningful and lasting contributions to the local newspaper industry.

Press Forward relies on donations to lobby for policy that supports local journalism, with an idea that the government should support local news. They also create local chapters to spread awareness about the necessity of local journalism, build infrastructure to support small newsrooms, and promote equity within the industry. Press Forward aims to create long-term pillars that will support local journalism far into the future.

Press Forward is not the only organization collecting philanthropic donations to invest in local news sources. The Lenfest Institute is an organization based in Philadelphia seeking to develop small newsrooms. Joseph Lichterman, Head of Communications and Editorials for the Lenfest Institute, said Lenfest is "building solutions for the next era of local news." The Lenfest Institute invests in the formulation of sustainable business models for the journalism community in Philadelphia, with hopes that the models can be repeated nationwide. For newspapers in the Philadelphia area, the Lenfest Institute offers grants to support investigative reporting, upgraded technology, and marketing.

"Not every solution is going to work for every community, and it's going to take a diversified mix of revenue. There still is a place for advertising in some capacity," Lichterman said, "But I think [newsrooms are] going to have to lean into reader revenue." He also noted that local newspapers should be looking to increase efficiencies and reduce production costs. Lichterman predicts that philanthropy will continue to occupy a major role in support of journalism as a public service, similar to its historical significance to support education and the arts.

Although the print advertising model of journalism may be gone, people turn to the news when they lose trust in other institutions or need to find information. Despite the growing pains local news outlets have faced in the 21st century, journalism continues to evolve, and this ensures its survival.

Never Again is Right Now: The Rise of the AfD in Germany

BY: **NICOLE CHEN**

"Faschisten sind keine alternative für Deutschland." Fascists are not an alternative for Germany. "Kein platz für nazis." No place for Nazis. "Nie wieder ist genau jetzt." Never again is right now. From Berlin to Munich and from Hamburg to Dresden, these slogans hang in every plaza and echo across every street.

This rhetoric, which is reminiscent of the 1900s-era resistance movement against the Nazi regime, is part of today's large-scale pro-democracy demonstrations in Germany. According to the German Interior Ministry, these demonstrations have attracted over 2.4 million supporters since mid-January. Some organizations estimate the participation at more than 3.6 million people. The root of the protests lies in growing anger and frustration with Germany's far-right party, the Alternative for Germany (AfD), and its disturbing extremist agenda.

Photo Credit: Wolfgang Rattay/ Reuters

Founded in 2013, the AfD emerged as a political contender with a platform centered around economic dissatisfaction. Its origin lies in the Global Economic Crisis of 2008, which triggered the European debt crisis. As a result, many Eurozone countries were unable to pay their government debt. The AfD, with a founding cohort of free-market economists and academics, opposed German-backed bailouts to the indebted governments. It also challenged the adoption of the euro on the basis that it led to high levels of trade imbalances, which exacerbated skepticism about the European Union.

"The AfD was not initially a far-right party in its founding," said Prof. Dr. Kai Arzheimer, a professor of Political Science at the University of Mainz and a leading expert on the AfD and the far-right in Europe. Instead, the AfD was a "party that consisted of people who could have been or were in fact members of center-right parties, but always had a strange mix of right wingers on its team." However, "the party began to transform quite quickly," Arzheimer asserted.

Originally, the party failed to muster even 5% of the votes required to meet the threshold to enter federal parliament (Bundestag). Now, they hold close to 11% of the seats in the German legislature.
The growth can be mostly attributed to the diversification of the AfD's political platform. The party incorporated new, far-right policies alongside its original eurosceptic, economy-focused approach. Prof. Dr. Alexander Wuttke, the Professor of Digitalization and Political Behavior at the Ludwig Maximilian University of Munich, said, "there has been a reservoir for parties to tap into xenophobia, widespread dissatisfaction with the political system, or anti-elitist sentiment, all of which has existed for quite some time in Germany."

Arzheimer echoed Wuttke's perspective. "Upon its transformation, the AfD fit the stereotype of a European radical right party, so it became very anti-immigration, anti-climate change, anti-gender equality. Whatever you imagine, [the party] did it all," he said.

The AfD's broad platform attracted new voters and led to a significant increase in membership from nearly 17,000 members in 2013 to around 40,000 in 2024. The expansion signals a deepening divide between Germans over the meaning of their national identity, and it necessitates a reexamination of Germany's complex history and contemporary problems.

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Some have attributed the rise of the AfD indirectly to former Chancellor of Germany Angela Merkel, the leader of the Christian Democratic Union (CDU), one of Germany's conservative parties. She is described in a Time article as "a symbol of stability, a 'civil servant-in-chief, floating above parties.'" But her drive for consensus may have had unintended consequences. "The CDU has shifted toward the center-left of the political spectrum in the last decade under Angela Merkel's leadership, [creating] an opening for the AfD," said Nathan Illies, a Politics, Philosophy and Economics student at the University of Bayreuth in Germany and a current Carlo Schmid Fellow at the United Nations in Washington, D.C..

Proponents of the AfD suggest that the current government, led by Chancellor Olaf Scholz of the center-left party, the Social Democratic Party (SPD), in coalition with the liberal Free Democratic Party (FDP), and the Greens, has had an unsatisfactory track record.

"Partly because of the nature of the complexity, partly because of strife and political ineptitude, the German government's leading elites have not found answers to Germany's problem," said Rüdiger Bachmann, a Stepan Family College Professor of Economics at the University of Notre Dame who holds dual citizenship from the United States and German. "This coalition really had a chance to modernize Germany, to stick together. The way they are conducting themselves, we have sort of three parties, ideologically far apart. There was a hope that [the coalition] could work on a project with a narrative to benefit modernization, and that just never happened."

The AfD's main concerns have worried German citizens for decades, but other issues have recently developed. According to Nathan Illies, "people are presently very unhappy with the coalition of the SPD, the Greens, and the FDP. The government has failed to stimulate the economy after the COVID pandemic and inflation, effectively address the challenges posed by the increasing numbers of migrants, or restrict Germany's structural budget deficit. Instead, the coalition, amidst public infighting and disputes, pursues an unpopular green agenda, including banning oil and gas heating systems, despite widespread protests against these compulsory regulations."

And it is these policies causing dissatisfaction that the AfD has strategically weaponized to attract more supporters. "The AfD attracts dissatisfied citizens by creating the perception that there are simple solutions to complex problems," said Ludwig Illies, a Politics student at Kings College London from Coburg, Bavaria.

Just as economic disaffection was the fundamental reason for the AfD's

"Upon its transformation, the AfD fit the stereotype of a European radical right party, so it became very anti-immigration, anti-climate change, anti-gender equality. Whatever you imagine, [the party] did it all"

founding, it continues to be a policy priority today. Since the 2000s, Germany has experienced an outflow of private capital due to slow domestic demand and weak business activity. Thus, German governments have struggled to attract investment in economic growth and are under constant pressure to stabilize financial markets. As Bachmann straightforwardly put it, "there is a feeling, and not unjustifiably so, that Germany is having economic difficulties."

In 2023, German labor shortages prevented progress in construction and energy-intensive industries. Generally, "there is a lack of labor supply right now in Germany at every skill level," said Bachmann.

In addition to the challenge posed by labor shortages, the ongoing Russia-Ukraine war has increased the price of energy and led to higher inflation rates. The purchasing power of households decreased, while the cost of living increased. Consequently, citizens lost faith in the government's ability to address their needs and looked for other options to improve their prospects. The AfD offered just that—an alternative to the spectrum of established parties.

The AfD promised to redirect money from foreign aid, including assistance to Ukraine, toward domestic development. To revitalize the German economy while staying in line with the party's foundational free-market principles, they also proposed minimizing government subsidies, lowering taxes, and eliminating wealth and inheritance taxes. For those experiencing stagnation and economic insecurity under the current administration, these proposals appear like a much-needed change.

Perhaps the most impactful topic on the AfD agenda, however, is its stance on immigration and its perceived resulting shift in German values.

In 2015, escalating wars in the Middle East and the onset of the Arab Winter led to an influx of migrants and refugees seeking entry to European countries. In response, many European nations tightened their border policies. Despite backlash from her own party, then-chancellor Merkel chose an open policy, processing applications from approximately 1.5 million asylum seekers between 2015-2019. The policy overextended the country's resources and carrying capacity, leading to anti-immigration protests and stricter immigration controls.

According to Arzheimer, "many people had the impression that Germany was losing control of the border. And that made it possible to start a party that splintered from the mainstream and transformed to a more radical right party."

Jannik Schilling, a German-born venture capitalist with deep ties to both Germany and the U.S., said that the pursuit of liberal immigration policy has pushed people who "oppose immigration and asylum practices" and "do not feel represented by the established parties" to the "far, far right because [the AfD is the party] that opposes immigration practices the strongest."

The AfD, for many voters, represents a radical, new path forward with an extreme position on immigration. Prof. Dr. Anselm Hager, an international politics professor in the Institute of Social Sciences at Humboldt University in Berlin, said that the AfD is "very strict on not having immigration, and some [in the party] have even suggested expatriating current Germans with a migratory background."

In 2023, in Potsdam, Germany, AfD members attended a secret conference with Martin Sellner, an infamous Austrian right-wing extremist, who gave a presentation about "remigration," a euphemism referring to the forced removal of asylum seekers and non-assimilated German citizens. Although the AfD claimed that none of its

"They are worried about the future of their children. Th

members attended in an official capacity, the presence of AfD representatives and affiliates nevertheless incited public outrage.

On a fundamental level, current conversations around anti-immigration reflect a purported shift in the cultural values and social identity of Germany. For example, PEGIDA (Patriotic Europeans Against the Islamisation of the West), an extremist political movement group based in Eastern Germany, sensationalizes a white nationalist conspiracy theory that argues Islam will conquer Europe if Germany continues to accept more immigrants. As Hager put it, immigration is perhaps "a threat about status loss—people feel like things are changing for the worse individually and for the country at large, which worsens their standing in society."

The climate crisis, the pandemic, and the Russia-Ukraine War are also important drivers of the AfD's growing popularity.

Addressing climate change is a significant goal of the current government, especially because of its coalition with the Greens. "Although most people recognize the existence of a climate crisis, many view the government's approach of addressing it critically. A primary worry is that these environmental policies might negatively impact the economy," said Ludwig Illies. The AfD, while recognizing that the climate is changing, denies that humans are the root cause. Thus, the party maintains that fossil fuels are a necessity for Germany, and that people should be able to live without government policies forcing them to make energy use transitions.

Another recent factor influencing the AfD's stances has been the COVID-19 pandemic. Ludwig Illies said that the pandemic represented a "significant event that led to societal divisions based on a wide array of differing opinions." The AfD criticized the German government for handling the pandemic by imposing lockdown measures, and former AfD Bundestag repre-

hey are concerned about the way the country is going."

Photo Credit: Thomas Imo/photothek/picture alliance

sentative Florian Jäger went as far as to "[equate] the injustice of the Nazis against the Jews with the measures to contain the COVID-19 pandemic." The AfD manipulatively tapped into uncertainty surrounding the pandemic, portraying public health measures as oppressive and an infringement on freedoms, thereby appealing to voters who were fearful and susceptible to misinformation.

The Russia-Ukraine War also contributed to the AfD's ascent. According to Bachmann, "there will be a military transformation with the increased threat from Putin; Germany will have to do more for European security." For the AfD, this idea is incompatible with its policy priorities. As Ludwig Illies said, "while a large portion of Germany, along with the current government, is in strong support of Ukraine, the AfD has adopted a more reserved position, suggesting a focus on domestic financial priorities." In line with its Eurosceptic roots, the AfD has repudiated EU sanctions against Russia and continues to visit Russian-occupied areas like Crimea, indicating its aim to restore economic and political ties with the Kremlin and "normalcy" in Germany.

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The AfD has strategically targeted voters. Alongside maintaining a strong social media presence to engage with young voters, they have also focused on the demographics most likely to receive the party agenda well.

"Being unemployed is a major driver for right support in many European countries; the same goes for the AfD," said Kai Arzheimer. "The majority of the voters are reasonably well-off middle class, lower middle-class, but they are all worried about the future. They are worried about the future of their children. They are concerned about the way the country is going." Anselm Hager agreed, highlighting a distinction between perception and reality: "It's not necessarily the case that poor voters tend to flock to the AfD. The more convincing explanation that I have come across has to do with perceptions about the mainstream party not doing so well." Notably, the AfD's support displays a distinct regional divide between East and West Germany. As Bachmann said, "East Germans were never exposed, or only belatedly exposed, to democratic reeducation and were left with less than favorable circumstances. They witnessed a collapse of their livelihood and their economy. For many of them, the whole idea of Germany being deeply rooted in a western democratic, rule-of-law type situation probably has less appeal than for West Germans."

Schilling expanded on this, positing that "even 30 years after reunification, there are still significant differences—such as a lower GDP per capita or lower employment rate—between East and West Germany." He added that "many of the most skilled workers have left East Germany, partially due to wage differences with West Germany. This leaves behind some people who did not have that option. The dynamic is slowly changing, as there are now more university towns and employment opportunities, but the change has been very gradual."

Arzheimer claimed that economics may not paint the full picture. "The south of the former GDR (German Democratic Republic) is an area where many people are very unhappy about politics, even though this is the most economically advanced part of the former GDR and reasonably well-run states. Yet, still, there is a sense of being mistreated by history and of being alienated from the government," he said. Many individuals in this area continue to harbor historical grudges, leading to a sense of disconnect from the government that even improved material conditions fails to alleviate.

In light of these factors, Bachmann said that "it is perhaps no surprise that most of [the AfD's] vote share is somewhat concentrated in East Germany." However, he also acknowledged that "it is wrong to only perceive this as a problem of East Germany: the AfD has considerable vote shares in West German states, too."

History is important to understanding the regional divide of support, but it is also crucial to understanding the way in which the AfD has used memory politics to garner support. The AfD has challenged notions of guilt associated with Germany's past, contending that all nations have their share of bad history. To this end, they have appealed to nostalgia and invoked selective interpretations of history to garner support: using a Nazi-era symbol to protest against gender-inclusive rhetoric, reclaiming Nazi language, and questioning the Holocaust commemoration policy.

In discussing the importance of historical remembrance in the AfD, Wuttke said that "there is a strong norm against anything that tries to pick up on the Third Reich. It is a clear taboo, but it seems that our constitutional culture, which has been a consensus for quite some time, is being challenged." While "[the AfD] cannot overtly argue against democracy, they can challenge it subtly by proposing a limit on historical education on Nazi Germany or lamenting a dedicated space to a large memorial in the city center of Germany's capital," Wuttke explained.

"The Holocaust and remembrance has been a defining feature of postwar Germany," Hager elaborated. "It has been one of the reasons that, for a long time, we have not had a very far-right party because it was always part of our DNA that it should never happen again. 'Never again' is the slogan.

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Photo Credit: dpa picture alliance / Alamy Stock Photo

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But of course, the genie is out of the bottle."

Jason Stanley, the Jacob Urowsky Professor of Philosophy at Yale University and author of How Fascism Works: the Politics of Us and Them, commented on the discussion surrounding the AfD's weaponization of German identity. "If you take your country's identity to be standing for liberalism, standing for equality, standing for freedom, and standing for values that are admirable, it is okay to be patriotic and say that these are your values," Stanley said. "But if patriotism means being proud of your country just because you think it is better than others, it is no longer patriotism: it becomes supremacy."

While it is fine to be proud of democracy, what the AfD is pushing, Stanley explained, is that Germans "should believe that their Fatherland is the greatest country on Earth and needs to be kept pure." In this case, the AfD has left patriotism behind and is "getting into ethno-nationalism."

For Selma Sondern, a PhD candidate in Modern History at the University of St. Andrews, who lives and works in Berlin, the AfD's emphasis on German identity may carry a hidden benefit. She recognized that "compared to other countries, it is very hard to be comfortable and patriotic waving around a German flag, for example. People react differently to that." But, at the same time, this may provide the opportunity to "foster a new dialogue about how Germans allow themselves to think about their nation and their identity." She noted that there needs to be "a new conversation about patriotism in Germany" in order "to create a balanced and historicized way of identifying with Germany that allows more than we currently allow ourselves."

Some point to the fact that there are many other ways to show pride for Germany's culture and democracy without resorting to extremism. Karoline Meta Beisel, who is the deputy head of the politics section at Süddeutsche Zeitung, the biggest broadsheet daily newspaper in Germany, shared one story.

"In 2006, the World Cup was held in Germany. German people are crazy for soccer, so you had these German flags and signs all over Germany. It was one of the rare times that people had this feeling of it being acceptable, even liberating, to wave a German flag in certain circumstances. That was an occasion where you would see a lot of German flags and not be associated with Nazi Germany." This example illustrates that there are alternative means to express national pride without neglecting Germany's past. As Beisel succinctly put it, "I don't think that you need to vote for AfD to have ways to feel patriotic."

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Citizens who feel the same way as Beisel have taken to the streets to demonstrate their staunch opposition to the AfD and its policies. Wuttke, who has participated in two of the protests himself in Munich, stated that "they were some of the biggest protests that the city has ever seen." He noted that "we have always had protests in Germany, but now people will take their evenings just to say 'I want democracy.'"

Hager also remarked that "the protests were quite surprising. Sure there was a catalyst, the secret meeting, but for anyone studying the far-right for a long time, it was common knowledge. But people saw it, and it gained a lot of traction, so it was the big spark that led people to take to the streets. And there were a lot of people."

Sondern shared that the protests even managed to transcend the stark East-West divide that still exists in Germany. "Protests did not just happen in a big city like Berlin," she said. "They happened in really random and very small places as well. And I think it is great to see that there is a political consciousness that appeared a bit dormant, coming back."

The demonstrations, Beisel said, "were [originally] protesting the AfD and extremism, but in some places, they were also about rage against the system more generally. Some people are not happy with the government's conservative shift." She

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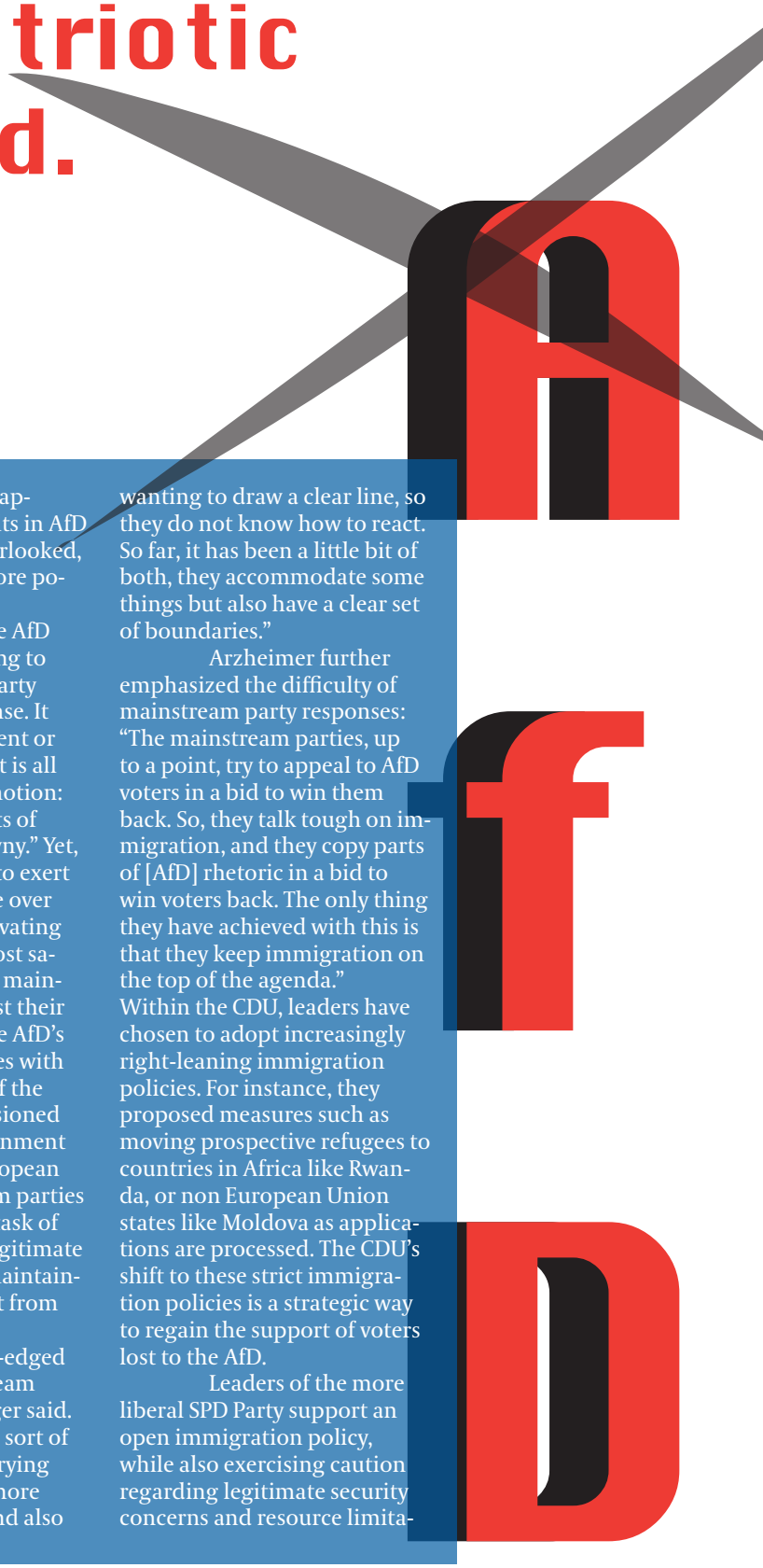

added that these protests are not limited to a certain group or demographic. Instead, "it's a broad mixture of people. It's not only young people, but also old people. There are even grandmothers who gather and hold up signs that say 'Grandmas Against the Far Right.'" She also remarked that the most impressive thing was that the protests were continuing to happen today, months after the secret meeting was revealed.

Alongside this public fervor, the mainstream parties, the CDU and SPD, are strategizing about responses to the rise of the AfD and reflecting on political approaches to address the concerns raised by protestors.

Generally speaking, the mainstream parties have agreed against collaboration with the AfD. The leader of the CDU, Friedrich Merz, has said that the AfD is anti-democratic and that its values are incompatible with German principles. Wuttke said, "there has been a phase of ignoring the new party—which is known as a 'firewall' that separates the mainstream party from the AfD. Not cooperating with the new party marks the AfD as not viable or an illegitimate political competitor." Ludwig Illies elaborated, "this approach, however, results in AfD supporters feeling overlooked, which only leads to more polarization."

The rise of the AfD is perplexing. According to Bachmann, "the AfD party program makes no sense. It is not internally coherent or reflective of the facts. It is all about appealing to emotion: to people with instincts of xenophobia or misogyny." Yet, the AfD still manages to exert considerable influence over political discourse, elevating immigration as the most salient issue and forcing mainstream parties to adjust their political strategies. The AfD's radical stance resonates with a significant portion of the public who are disillusioned with the current government and the erosion of European values. The mainstream parties thus face the difficult task of responding to these legitimate concerns, while also maintaining an identity distinct from the AfD.

"It's a double-edged sword for the mainstream party to respond," Hager said. "The center parties are sort of stuck between either trying to accommodate the more right-leaning voters and also wanting to draw a clear line, so they do not know how to react. So far, it has been a little bit of both, they accommodate some things but also have a clear set of boundaries."

Arzheimer further emphasized the difficulty of mainstream party responses: "The mainstream parties, up to a point, try to appeal to AfD voters in a bid to win them back. So, they talk tough on immigration, and they copy parts of [AfD] rhetoric in a bid to win voters back. The only thing they have achieved with this is that they keep immigration on the top of the agenda." Within the CDU, leaders have chosen to adopt increasingly right-leaning immigration policies. For instance, they proposed measures such as moving prospective refugees to countries in Africa like Rwanda, or non European Union states like Moldova as applications are processed. The CDU's shift to these strict immigration policies is a strategic way to regain the support of voters lost to the AfD.

Leaders of the more liberal SPD Party support an open immigration policy, while also exercising caution regarding legitimate security concerns and resource limita-

tions. The SPD has investigated legal action to ban the AfD and disqualify it from candidacy for its extremist positions.

A "new, allegedly left authoritarian populist outfit in Germany," also clouds the AfD's future, according to Arzheimer. The Bündnis Sahra Wagenknecht party has been "explicitly targeting former AFD voters, offering economically left and socially conservative policies" and is "polling around 5%." This new party has been forecasted to draw support away from the AfD, although supporting either extreme may not be a good solution to the problem of extremism.

Nevertheless, as a result of widespread anti-AfD and pro-democracy protests, the AfD's polling numbers have declined. It is uncertain whether the slight dip indicates a larger trend: whether the AfD has surpassed its peak popularity or if these recent events represent minor setbacks that may not affect the party long term.

For now, however, it seems that "mainstream parties are not winning voters back; in fact, they are losing more voters to the AfD," Arzheimer said. The AfD continues to make significant headway in state elections, especially in the East. Additionally, the upcoming European Parliament elections will include 16- and 17-year-old voters for the first time (as a result of a lowered voting age for this election), and numerous other municipal elections will be contested this year. Looking ahead, the federal elections scheduled for Autumn 2025 promise more shifts to Germany's political dynamic.

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Ultimately, the AfD has shrewdly framed cultural and political anxieties as threats to German identity and sovereignty. "People have seen AfD voters mainly as protest voters, but now this view has started to shift," Beisel said. "Now, AfD voters are perceived by many to truly believe that they are voting for the right politics for the country." As Hager shared, "the world is getting more complex. There's migration, there's globalization. So a lot of forces lead people to look for easy answers, perhaps idealizing the past."

The party has leveraged these issues, forcing the public to confront its historical legacy and engage in discussions about the meaning of German identity, linking this discourse to grievances that the present administration has been unable to satisfactorily address. While the ascendancy of the AfD threatens democracy, it also highlights the resilience of civil society in Germany. Pro-democracy protests reveal that most citizens reject a revisionist perspective of their history, instead opting to remember their past while striving to create a Germany that instills pride.

"These status-quo movements were surfacing everywhere, but one of their consequences may have been to prompt people to realize what they hold dear, and how precious and fragile democracy is," said Wuttke. "And people have started to internalize this, including myself, that we take democracy for granted, and we actually need to work for it on an ongoing basis."

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The Bounty of the Sea

A Public Good or an Industry Privilege?

BY: **ALESSANDRA PAPPALARDI**

With faces weathered by sun and sea and eyes crinkled from years battling salt water, the individuals sitting in the council room wear their lifetimes on their flannel sleeves. Idle hands, etched with scars and calluses, tell the story of rods cast and nets hauled in the pursuit of a daily catch. A figure stands, catching the attention of those in the room.

When he's not surveying the Long Island Sound from the captain's chair of his 42-foot charter boat, Captain James Joseph Schneider can be found here, in the meeting hall of the Recreational Fishing Alliance (RFA). The RFA is a nonprofit organization that represents the livelihoods of for-hire anglers.

For those involved in fishing culture along the coasts of Maine, New Hampshire, Massachusetts, New York, Connecticut and Rhode Island, the charter fishing industry is a crucial piece of the northeastern maritime economy.

Back at the RFA meeting, Schneider begins his plea. His voice cuts through the small talk that fills the room, commanding the council's attention.

With fifty years of experience on the water, the Long Island native is no stranger to the ebbs and flows of the northeastern seaboard. A seasoned for-hire recreational captain with ties to the fishery management sector, Schneider, who owns the aptly named James Joseph Schneider Fishing Company, understands the shifting currents of the fishing industry. But when it comes to navigating regulatory standards, even a fisherman as knowledgeable as Schneider faces challenges. It is these challenges that he frequently addresses during RFA discussions.

Schneider and other charter fishermen worry regulatory departments like the New York State Department of Conservation (NYSDEC) overlook charter livelihoods when setting regional fishing standards. During a discussion with The Politic this February, the veteran captain expressed concerns.

"As of right now, as we approach my season starting in April, I have no idea what the regulations are for this coming season," he continued, "I can't advertise. I can book trips for the few species that have predetermined regulations, but I still have no quota and size limit to set my trips up for the next few months."

Fishing regulations are important to protect the environment and prevent overfishing. But captains, anglers, and boaters in the recreational fishing industry collide with regulations they see as unnecessary and pernicious to their businesses.

Schneider feels that companies and individuals suffer when regulations disrupt recreation. The general charter customer population, which includes occasional anglers and families aiming

Captain Francis Pappalardi, Charter boat fisherman

Photos provided by Captain Francis Pappalardi, fisherman for Sound Bound Charters, pictured above

to preserve the American fishing tradition, can find themselves disadvantaged.

"The person that saves money to buy their fishing rod, that can only go fishing once a year and take their kids fishing on a charter boat or maybe go fish off the beach, they want to be able to keep one fish. They're not asking to wipe out the species, but part of the experience is taking the fish home, having dinner with their family, talking about it, and getting completely involved," Schneider said.

Captains in the Northeast generally share this opinion. Peter Cavallo, part-time captain for Sound Bound Charters, a company based out of New Rochelle, New York, agrees that some of the regulations on recreational fishermen are constraining. For example, size slots, which protect fish populations by requiring anglers to throw back small fish, disturb customer satisfaction.

"Catch-and-release is a great thing for conservation, but people are also looking for a meal at the end of the day. They're paying a high price to come out fishing, and to only be allowed to keep one fish in a three-inch slot is ridiculous. Utterly ridiculous," said Cavallo.

Furthermore, differences in licensing and permitting systems between states, specifically between Northeastern states that share the same waters and weather patterns, also represent a major gripe of charter fishers. Charter captains encounter incompatible requirements for obtaining permits, reporting catches, and adhering to safety standards depending on which side of the state line they operate.

Since 2005, Matt Casamassima has been the owner of Cos Cob Charters, a for-hire fishing company moored in Greenwich, Connecticut. He explained why an intertwined net of environmental standards set by different states present a challenge for fishermen.

"My boat is in Greenwich, but if I go west one mile, I'm in New York, and if I go straight, I'm in Connecticut. If you're fishing the [Long Island] Sound, sometimes you're fishing New York waters, and if you go far enough east, sometimes you're fishing Rhode Island waters," Casamassima said. Each state has competing expectations and rules, which makes it difficult for fishermen to comply with all of them.

The subsistence of captains like Schneider and Cavallo rely on customer satisfaction. The continued success of a daily catch permits a greater certainty of customer retention, ensuring pay for captains, mates and other members of their respective crews, as well as fuel, bait and mooring costs. With this constant pressure, many captains find the regulations suffocating. But these regulations exist for a reason, and those mired in the recreational fishing industry sometimes overlook the complexities intrinsic to creating them.

Environmental policy-makers balance both the socioeconomic and ecological ramifications of the guidelines they create. The joint imperative to protect and sustainably manage ocean resources for future generations, whilst also supporting the professions that depend heavily on the consumption of such resources, demands sound decision-making.

NYSDEC official Maureen Davidson discussed the internal processes that she and her colleagues oversee in simultaneously managing environmental values and supporting marine businesses. In an email to The Politic, she explained the intricacies that are involved in establishing conservation legislation.

"One of the major challenges is the requirement for DEC to manage and balance the needs of commercial fishermen, recreational anglers, and other users of our local marine waters. However, there are other interests, such as offshore wind projects, aquaculture, shoreside development, drilling and dredging projects, energy storage depots, and submarine cabling that compete too. DEC must weigh the value and needs of all parties competing for ocean resources."

Satisfying the diverse interests of all stakeholders is not the only challenge regulators face. Mark Grant, a fishery policy analyst with National Oceanic and Atmospheric Administration (NOAA) National Marine Services, added that setting national standards for federal waters, particularly when states act and impose conservation amendments independently, represents another difficulty.

"Because the states are independent and have their own processes for rulemaking, there can be a delay between when the government does something and state matches it. Or, a state might not choose to perfectly match what the federal government is doing," Grant explained.

"Catch-and-release is a great thing for conservation, but people are also looking for a meal at the end of the day. They're paying a high price to come out fishing, and to only be allowed to keep one fish in a three-inch slot is ridiculous. Utterly ridiculous"

"We fishermen should be the ones making laws to please ourselves, not politicians in a building that have never been fishing and don't know the industry"

As a board member of the New England Fishery Management Council (NEFMC), one of eight national councils that enforce regulations for fisheries, Grant directly engages with recreational fishermen. The analyst must also incorporate the perspective of another important stakeholder: the commercial fishing industry.

For generations, commercial fishing fleets have been the backbone of northeastern maritime economies. These fleets are often characterized by large-scale netting operations and are responsible for the continuous supply of seafood to national markets.

Charter fishing captains like Schneider generally acknowledge that fishing regulations are necessary for conservation. But, they often complain that the burden of regulation falls heaviest on recreational anglers over commercial fisheries, who are running larger-scale — and therefore potentially more environmentally harmful — operations. Because commercial fleets are responsible for hauling copious quantities of fish to shore in order to meet the needs of nationwide seafood aisles, quotas for the industry differ tremendously from the for-hire boats' daily trip limits. "There are two commercial boats in Montauk that own all of the quotas in the region, and it's just not fair," said Schneider.

It's not just quota differences that rankle charter fishermen. Because of the varying methods they use to catch fish, commercial boats are also subject to disparate rules for another important regulation: catch size.

"If you're a commercial fisherman, you can keep a 14-inch summer flounder, which is pretty small. For recreational fishing, it looks like we might be up to a 19-inch fish this year. That's a big difference," said Lake, "Recreational anglers don't think it's fair that the commercial guys can keep the smaller fish."

But from Lake's position as a policymaker, he explained that there are reasons behind the dissimilar expectations for commercial versus recreational anglers. For one thing, the different fishing methods used by the two groups would make applying the same standards to both a challenge.

"While commercial does sometimes use rod and reel, they also use a whole suite of other gears to get the fish, including otter trawls, which are nets they drag behind the boat. They set these nets stationary, and let the fish passively swim into them," explained John Lake, supervising marine biologist of the Rhode Island Department of Environmental Management (DEM).

Because trawling by nature prohibits fishermen from measuring their collected fish at the time of harvest, size slots tend to be looser within the commercial sector. However, despite the common image of commercial vessels as dominant titans of the sea, the reality is scaled down.

Mark Grant, the NOAA fishery policy analyst, understands the concerns of recreational for-hire captains along the Northeast from Maine to Florida. However, he emphasized that many misconceptions exist in the public's knowledge of commercial fishing vessels.

"I think we now have maybe 150 commercial vessels that land around fish for profit. So while people's perception of commercial fishing is one of a really big operation, that's not the case anymore," Grant said.

Beyond the quantity of vessels, Grant noted that commercial fishing quotas are highly regulated — more so than many recreational fishermen realize. In fact, the perceived magnitude of commercial harvests is largely inflated, as reaps have been meticulously monitored through increasingly stringent policies.

Interestingly, commercial fishermen undergo more surveillance than their charter counterparts."This year, [commercial vessels] are required to have monitoring on 90% of their trips, whether it's a human or video cameras. Starting this May, we want it to go into 100%. We have very accurate data about what they catch, what they keep, what they discard, where and when," Grant said.

In fact, marine policy officials largely agree that commercial boats face more regulations than charter vessels. Though charter vessels experience smaller bag limits, the oversight of these policies cannot be standardized to the same extent as the commercial industry.

Despite common conceptions, the commercial fishing industry has many surveillance tools in place to prevent overfishing and regulation noncompliance. The same cannot be said about recreation.

The recreational fishing sector is not just composed of charter boats. It also includes individuals on the shorelines or their own independent boats fishing for fun. This makes it almost impossible to establish an official regulatory system for the recreational sector as a whole. While certified charter captains answer to NOAA and U.S. Coast Guard Inspection Services, shoreline fishermen and other individuals fishing for themselves are primarily subject to park

Suzanne Elizabeth Romano aboard charter ship Joel-L in the Long Island Sound 1997

management guidelines and a loose honor system. Thus, commercial crews tend to be responsible for complying with regulations to a greater degree than recreational fishermen.

Grant confirmed that in Maine, where cod and haddock are the main catch, the bulk of the harvest is actually caught by the recreational sector, including both for-hire captains and independent fishermen: "In the case of cod, for example, more than half of the total catch is recreational fishermen and not commercial, which a lot of people are very surprised to hear."

While the perception of unfairness around separate regulations for commercial boats may be misguided, individuals such as Dr. Justin Davis of the Connecticut Department of Energy & Environmental Protection (DEEP) understand the roaring tide of frustration from the recreational sector. Davis realizes that quelling the turmoil is no easy task.

"From the standpoint of fairness and equity amongst all people participating in the recreational sector, I can see the argument that there's a fundamental unfairness there if you're giving people the opportunity to pay money for a different access to the resource. I don't think there's a right or wrong answer there. That's the challenge. The more you give the for-hire sector a different set of regulations, it can create a setup where other folks in the sector look at that as an unfair advantage," Davis said.

Direct communication between officials and representatives across the fishing industries has become more necessary as the sector grows in size and complexity. Those invested in the marine arena, like James Schneider, have dedicated their lives to providing personal insight on the matters.

For 40 years Schneider has driven up and down the Northeast, attending council meetings and communicating his feelings about fishing regulations. He would like to see members of the recreational fishing community more welcomed to share their perspectives with policy-makers. Casamassima agreed, noting that many in the for-hire community wonder whether conservation officials have sought out a "voice for the for-hire fleet or commercial fishermen or guys that are on the water every day."

Creating regulations that satisfy the wishes of the various stakeholders in the northeast fishing industry is a complex task. Still, commercial and charter fishermen feel that more could be done to provide community outreach in the creation of these regulations.

Peter Lauda, a commercial fisherman and a colleague of Schneider, weighed in. He runs both Target Rock Lobster & Bottom Fishing Charters, a for-hire business docked in Long Island, and Lauda's Lobsters, a commercial operation. With a finger on the pulse of both the commercial and for-hire world, he voiced the concerns of fishers across the industries.

"We fishermen should be the ones making laws to please ourselves, not politicians in a building that have never been fishing and don't know the industry," Lauda declared.

Conservation officials like Grant and Davis certainly do seek the insight of coastal natives with personal stakes in the fishing game. But a greater effort to incorporate these perspectives — an opportunity for both commercial and recreational fishermen to see themselves represented in industry laws — could make for calmer seas surrounding this stormy issue. As it stands, the need for well-informed policy may be an opportunity to both protect marine environments and incorporate the unique input of those that rely on them. It could provide a space for bureaucrats, fishermen, captains, and businesses to come together and work toward a legislative framework that reflects the patchwork of interests swirling in the seas off the northeastern coast.

Photos provided by Captain Francis Pappalardi, fisherman for Sound Beach Charters

BY: **SOPHIA LIU**

Zaina Arafat is an LGBTQ Palestinian-American writer. She is the author of the novel, You Exist Too Much, *which won a 2021 Lambda Literary Award and was named Roxane Gay's favorite book of 2020. Told in vignettes that flash between the U.S. and the Middle East—from New York to Jordan, Lebanon, and Palestine—*You Exist Too Much *traces its protagonist's journey for two of our most intense longings—love, and a place to call home. Arafat's stories and essays have appeared in publications including* The New York Times, Granta, *and* The Believer. *She lives in Brooklyn and is currently at work on a collection of essays.*

Interrogating Identity

A Conversation with Zaina Arafat

YOU EXIST TOO MUCH IS A STORY ABOUT HEALING. DID WRITING AND PUBLISHING THE BOOK HELP YOU HEAL?

Yes. I think writing emotionally and physically affects you because you write your way through something. Something that obstructs your ability to move forward in the world. For me, the issues that the protagonist is grappling with—her sexuality, her biculturalism—are issues I also relate to as a Palestinian-American queer woman. I can definitely say that who I was when I started writing this book and who I am now is different. The book has been a journey that has been a bridge for me to get to where I am now, and I have transcended a lot of pain.

WHILE THE NARRATOR ADMITS HERSELF TO A TREATMENT CENTER TO GET HELP FOR HER "LOVE ADDICTION", WHAT ARE WAYS OF HEALING WITHOUT INSTITUTIONAL SUPPORT? HOW CAN WE TAKE CARE OF OURSELVES IN A WORLD SO FRAUGHT WITH VIOLENCE?

Forming communities is hugely important for healing and taking care of oneself. The communities in my own life, such as my writing community, my queer community, my fellow Arab American community, have been a huge source of strength and healing. We're in a space in a world that's filled with so much pain, violence, and horror. Without community, I think I would feel so rudderless and so much more helpless. I also think taking healthy actions can be really helpful towards healing. I like to run and I'm participating in a 5k this weekend, and that is really uplifting and nourishing. I also think family, even though it is an institution in some sense, is important because family teaches you how to find the good in and multi-dimensionalize people.

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ON THAT NOTE, FAMILY, AND ESPECIALLY MOTHERHOOD, PLAYS A CRUCIAL ROLE IN YOU EXIST TOO MUCH. HOW DOES YOUR FAMILY INFLUENCE YOUR WORK, AND HOW DID THEY RESPOND TO THE BOOK'S PUBLICATION?

So much of the book is about intergenerational dynamics between immigrants and first generation Palestinian-Americans, which was influenced by my growing up. My mom and dad had a different culture and spoke a different language than myself. Interestingly, they were supportive of the book. They've also been incredibly supportive of me as a writer, which is amazing and shocking, honestly. I also hoped that this book could be relatable to other people who are the children of immigrants, outside of the Palestinian community.

THE EXPLORATION OF HOW CULTURE EXACERBATES THE NARRATOR'S CONFLICT WITH HER SEXUALITY REALLY STOOD OUT TO ME, ESPECIALLY THE LINE: "A RELATIONSHIP WITH A WOMAN MEANT FAILURE: I HAD FAILED TO GET A MAN, FAILED TO FIND SOMETHING NORMAL, FAILED TO NOT BE PATHETIC." WHEN BUILDING THIS NOVEL, HOW MUCH OF IT DID YOU WANT TO BE DRIVEN BY SEXUALITY?

Sexuality is obviously at the heart of the book in many ways. The narrator discovers and accepts her sexuality. She falls in love with women that are unattainable because that's the safest way for her to express her sexuality. At the same time, the narrator comes from a culture where it feels unacceptable to inhabit her sexuality in a genuine way. Being Palestinian, Muslim, and queer is not necessarily compatible. But also, I think sexuality is a symptom of her relationship with herself. The narrator has a lot of internally-imposed shame. Her sexuality is an outward manifestation of that shame and her fear of not being acceptable.

RECOUNTING THE INTIFADA THAT SHE EXPERIENCED AS A SIX YEAR OLD, THE NARRATOR SAYS, "BUT I REMEMBER, PERHAPS BECAUSE I WANT TO. I CAN JUST AS EASILY FORGET WHEN I WANT." THIS IS SUCH A FASCINATING LINE, AND I WONDER HOW YOU CAME TO IT. HOW DOES PERSONAL MEMORY SITUATE ITSELF IN HISTORIC MEMORY? DOES MEMORY CONTRIBUTE TO THE ALIENATION THAT THE NARRATOR, AS AN IMMIGRANT, FEELS?

That lineharkens to the idea that memories are created by stories—stories that you've heard from your parents that they lived through and were traumatized by. Those experiences trickle down to you. It can be hard to know what belongs to you. What is your personal memory versus a story you've been told? What pieces of memory stick to you? And what do you choose to forget and block out? I think that

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the narrator intentionally forgets often, because she keeps repeating the same destructive patterns. She can remember when she wants to and forget just as easily. It’s a cycle of willful forgetting. This also speaks to this idea of what belongs to you. What are your personal traumas? What are your collective traumas? How do these two get mixed up or confused or parsed together when they should be parsed apart?

YOU EXIST TOO MUCH SPLICES THE NARRATOR’S PRESENT-DAY LIFE WITH FLASHBACKS FROM HER PAST. THE NARRATOR EXPLAINS HER PARENTS’ RELATIONSHIP WITH A METAPHOR ABOUT HAMAS AND ISRAEL AND DEFENDS HERSELF AGAINST OTHER PEOPLE’S MISUNDERSTANDINGS ABOUT THE ISRAELI-PALESTINIAN CONFLICT AT THE TREATMENT CENTER. HOW DO YOU ACCEPT, OR HAVE YOU ACCEPTED, THE NEED TO REPEAT AND TO REEXPLAIN YOURSELF AND YOUR HISTORY TO PEOPLE?

I have accepted it. Since October, people have asked why they have to do the emotional labor of explaining what’s going on. People often say that it’s not their job to explain, whereas I feel like it is. Because otherwise, it will never be explained. It’s frustrating, in some sense, but I hope that I can explain in an artful and, at times, humorous way. The metaphor with the narrator’s parents being Hamas and Israel is not funny in the current context, but it’s meant to be a cheeky shorthand that conveys information about these two factions. I’ve accepted the need to explain, and I will do that explaining if I have to, until the day I die. I feel like the benefit of being a Palestinian-American, and not being seen as a typical Palestinian that people often immediately shut off, is my ability to get through.

YOU SAID IN AN INTERVIEW WITH PEN AMERICA THAT ONCE, AN EDITOR STRUCK THE WORD “PALESTINE” FROM YOUR WRITING AND WROTE IN THE MARGINS, “PALESTINE DOES NOT EXIST.” HAVE YOU HAD SIMILAR EXPERIENCES SINCE THEN? HOW HAS THE PUBLISHING INDUSTRY BEEN AFFECTED BY THE ESCALATION OF THE ISRAELI-PALESTINIAN CONFLICT IN THE PAST MONTHS?

Yes, I have had similar experiences. Not to that degree of blatancy, but there have been experiences that have been very problematic. Editors have reached out to me and asked me to write things now, which is fantastic. Usually, it’s with an empathetic sort of desire to hear from Palestinians or the Palestinian diaspora. At the same time, I’ve been told that several editors or publishers are Zionist and are not going to publish my work. I think that’s even more the case right now.

YOU ALSO MENTION EDWARD SAID IN THE BOOK. HOW HAS SAID’S, OR OTHER PALESTINIAN WRITERS’, WORK INFLUENCED YOUR WRITING AND TEACHING PRACTICE?

Said has influenced me to have the courage to be out here writing as a Palestinian. He has influenced myself and other Palestinian authors like Randa Jarrar and Hala Alyan to call ourselves Palestinian. Edward Said is a genius when it comes to how Orientalism is so unbelievably pervasive and limiting. I’ve thought a lot about that as a writer because I was expected to play into that Orientalism. When I was submitting my book, there were requests from agents or editors to add more camels or more spices because they were exotic Orientalist imagery. And I was just thinking, gosh, that’s exactly what I’m trying to push against. I don’t want to tell a story that falls into an Orientalist framework.

WHAT ARE YOU CURRENTLY WORKING ON?

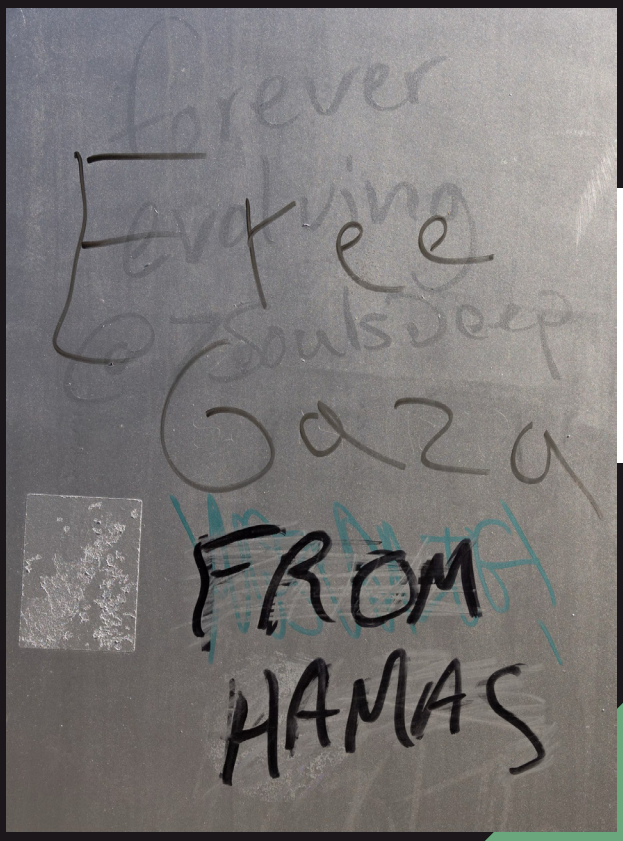
I’m writing an essay collection and another novel about an artist, set between Europe and the Middle East, as opposed to the United States and the Middle East.

Street Politics

BY: **RORY SCHOENBERGER**

New Haven is a hub for activism of all kinds. While many attribute this heightened political engagement to Yale's presence, the extent of political graffiti throughout the city beyond Yale suggests this assumption is flawed.

"Rest in Peace Malik Jones" is sprayed above the Union Station train tracks. In 1997, Malik Jones, an unarmed Black man, was shot by police after a chase from East Haven to New Haven. Three decades later, the community remembers this act of police brutality.



Opposite the "Tax Yale" sticker, "Free Gaza" is written in thin black pen. Below it, another person has added "From Hamas."

A "Tax Yale" sticker is placed on a publically funded New Haven bridge. If Yale, which is not required to pay taxes on its academic property, were taxed at the same rate as others in New Haven, it would owe the city an additional 95 million dollars annually.

Here, an "Are you a Communist?...Then get organized!" poster has been scribbled over. The phrases "I <3 USA" and "This is the USA!" have been added.

This "We the Resilient" sticker, created by Artist Ernesto Yerena, shows Indigenous activist Helen Red Feather protesting the construction of the Dakota Access Pipeline. This 2016 protest, which aimed to preserve Standing Rock Sioux land, was violently suppressed by policemen, injuring 300 people.

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